



Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

Talk about what you were doing in the past!



Learning Outcome

Understand actions, events, and experiences in present, past or future and in spoken or written texts and in work and social contexts.

Ask your partner:

- What were you doing last night?
- What did you watch on T.V. yesterday?

Can Do Statements

- I can talk about relationships and character traits.
- I can talk about possible or uncertain events in the past.
- I can explain the sequence of events in the past.





Let's Explore!

Sally always **lands on her feet***.

* To "*land on your feet*" means to be lucky or successful after you have been in a difficult situation.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

- Amy:** Wow, we couldn't have had better timing.
Peter: We should have gotten here sooner, but Vanessa slowed us down.
Vanessa: Brrr. I'm sorry. I couldn't have run any faster. I wore the wrong shoes. I thought we were going out on the town not snowshoeing. You should have carried me, Peter.
Peter: Oh, I would have carried you, but chivalry is dead. Oww!
Amy: Hi, table for three.
Vanessa: The weather report could have told us there was going to be a blizzard. I didn't hear anything about it.
Amy: I think it's beautiful. Excuse me, I need to go to the washroom.
Peter: So what were you doing when I called last night? I got your machine.
Vanessa: I was writing an e-mail to Sally when you called. Sorry. I didn't feel like answering.
Peter: Oh, so what is Sally up to these days?
Vanessa: Well this month, initially, she was living in Austria and she was skiing everyday while working in a ski resort near Innsbruck. Next, she was planning a trip to Italy, but then canceled that and went to Croatia instead.
Peter: Yeah. But after that, I read on her blog that she was traveling to Bratislava because she wanted to go to Moscow after. That was a week ago. She wants to ride the Trans-Siberian railway remember?
Vanessa: Right. I forgot about that. Yeah, so now she must be in Moscow. I think she called the other day. I was taking a shower when the phone rang. By the time I picked it up, the person had hung up. The call display showed a Russian number. It was probably her. I hope she is okay.
Peter: You know Sally, she always lands on her feet.
Amy: What did I miss?
Peter: Nothing. Let's have some coffee.



Let's Practice!

What happened first? Then what? Let's write about the sequence of events in the past.

Instructions: Use the correct option from the box to fill the blanks in the paragraph.

rang / canceled / skiing / writing / called / But after that / were / was / wanted

_____ I read on her blog that she was traveling to Bratislava because she _____ to go to Moscow after. That _____ a week ago. So what _____ you doing when I _____ last night? I was _____ an e-mail to Sally when you called. Well this month, initially, she was living in Austria and she was _____ every day while working in a ski resort near Innsbruck. Next, she was planning a trip to Italy, but then _____ that and went to Croatia instead. I was taking a shower when the phone _____.



Let's Practice!

The three friends talk their personalities, interests and relationship.

Instructions: Match the options from Column A and Column B to correctly complete each sentence. Read the sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

COLUMN A

1. Let's have
2. Sally always lands
3. I didn't
4. I think
5. Chivalry is not
6. So what is Sally
7. I thought we were

COLUMN B

- a. dead.
- b. going out on the town.
- c. some coffee.
- d. up to these days?
- e. it's beautiful.
- f. feel like answering.
- g. on her feet.





Extension Activity

Talk about a past event with a coin.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Take a coin from your pocket. Look at the date.
- Write about the past events that happened in your life in that year. Was it a good year? Was it a bad year?
- Expand and add any past events that happened in your country or in the world.
- Write a short paragraph 8 to 10 sentences long.
- Share with a partner.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I talk about coincidences and strange events.

☐
☐

I discuss experiences I have and haven't had.

☐
☐

I write about past events.

☐
☐


Target Words

- **to go out on the town** (verb): to spend the whole evening out enjoying yourself
e.g. I thought we were going out on the town tonight.
- **snowshoeing** (noun): sport involving cross-country walks over snow
e.g. I thought we were going snowshoeing.
- **chivalry** (noun): very polite, honest, and kind behaviour, especially by men towards women
e.g. I would have carried you, but chivalry is dead.
- **blizzard** (noun): a severe snowstorm
e.g. The weather report could have told us there was going to be a blizzard.
- **call display** (noun): phone feature which displays the name and phone number of the person calling
e.g. The call display showed a Russian number.
- **to hang up** (verb): to put the receiver down, close your phone, or press the end call button
e.g. By the time I picked it up, the person had hung up.





Learning Points

Possibility and Uncertainty in the Past

There are different ways to express uncertainty and possibility about the past.

Look at the chart for a summary of what modals you can use and how to use them:

Modal	Meaning/Use	Example
Could have + past participle	You use this to express that something was possible or you had the skill to do it but you did not do it.	<i>I could have gone with them to the movie, but I decided not to.</i>
Couldn't have + past participle	You use this structure to say that something did not happen or you did not have the skill to do it in the past.	<i>I couldn't have called until now. There is a no phone policy in meetings (= it was impossible for me to have called earlier).</i>
Should have + past participle	You use this structure to say that something was good to do in the past, but you didn't do it. (regret)	<i>I should have taken a taxi, now I'll be late!</i>
Shouldn't have + past participle	You use this structure to say that something wasn't good to do in the past, but you did it. (regret)	<i>I shouldn't have talked so much!</i>
Shouldn't have + past participle	You use this structure to say that you expect this to have happened, because it was planned in the past.	<i>Their train should have gotten in by now (= if the train is on time, it has arrived).</i>
would have + past participle	You use this structure to say that you wanted to do something, but you did not, generally because there was a reason why you did not do it.	<i>I would have gone swimming if I had brought my bathing suit.</i>

Examples:

- *We couldn't have had better timing.*
- *We should have gotten here sooner, but Vanessa was slow.*
- *I couldn't have ran any faster.*
- *The weather report could have told us there was going to be a blizzard.*
- *I would have carried you, but chivalry is dead.*





Learning Points

The Past Continuous vs. The Simple Past

When you want to talk about two events that happened at the same time in the past, you can use either the **Simple Past** or the **Past Continuous** tenses.

For example:

Max was watching TV while Beth was making dinner.

Max watched TV while Beth made dinner.

When you choose to use the Past Continuous, you are focusing the fact that the event or action was in progress in the past.

When you choose to use the Simple Past, you are focusing on the fact that the event or action was completed.

When you talk about two past completed events, you use the Simple Past for both.

For example:

He got up after the alarm went off.

Examples:

- *Initially, she was living in Austria and she was skiing everyday while working in a ski resort near Innsbruck.*
- *Next, she was planning a trip to Italy.*
- *But then canceled that and went to Croatia instead.*
- *But after that, I read on her blog that she was traveling to Bratislava because she wanted to go to Moscow after.*
- *I was vacuuming the house when the phone rang.*
- *By the time I picked it up, the person had hung up.*

